

How did you get the name Raspberry Pi?

The name actually is an interesting mix. If you recall the old days of microcomputers, there was a fruit-naming tradition like Acron, Tangerine Computer Systems or Apricot Computers. Raspberry is a reference to that tradition. Pi was used because originally we wanted to produce a computer that could run only Python. So Pi is derived from Python. We began making Raspberry Pi but ended up making the device much more capable than what we had originally thought of.

There are several alternatives to Raspberry Pi available in the market right now. What is your take on them?

First of all, all the devices termed as alternatives to Raspberry Pi tend to be more expensive. No one has made a device at the same price point as ours. To the best of my knowledge, they are also less powerful when compared to the Raspberry Pi. All are based on Chinese APIs, so they tend to be low-performance devices. Having said that, we don't really mind people making low-cost devices because we are not for profit and none of us is going to get rich. But as of now, we do not see anyone measuring up to what Raspberry Pi has achieved in terms of performance and cost.

So you are not insecure about these devices?

I think we are doing okay. We are doing a lot of volumes. From a multimedia standpoint, I think the device we offer is more powerful than others. We are starting to build a community now and hope to see a good future.

Which of the available devices is Raspberry's closest competitor?

The one I would find interesting would be with a high performance. So I can think of three classes of competitors. First, the devices that are priced around \$60-70 and generally based on Chinese APIs. I don't find them better because they are more expensive than ours. Then there are devices which are much more expensive than ours and better in performance, like the Beagleboard. It is three to four times more expensive than the Raspberry Pi. The one that I really find interesting is Odroid, which is priced at around \$130. It is powered by an Exynos4412 Cortex-A9 quad-core processor. It does things that Raspberry Pi can't do, unlike the other devices that Raspberry Pi is competing with.

How many pieces of Raspberry Pi do you aim to ship?

I think shipping 50,000 pieces of the device monthly would be fine but we aspire to reach the level of 100,000 pieces.

But if we look at the current demand for Raspberry Pi, you are not able to meet it. Why have the shipments got delayed?

I think we are very close to meeting the demand and completing the orders. One of our two distributors made the Raspberry Pi delivery in August. So I think we are able to

catch up with the demand. Very soon, we will be able to not only meet the demand but also create a back-up of the stock.

What features are missing in Raspberry Pi just because it is a low-cost device?

The one feature that could have increased the adoption and popularity of Raspberry Pi is Wi-Fi. Another thing that I really find missing in Raspberry Pi is a camera. If I ever go for a new interface, I would add a camera to it, for sure. Regarding the rest of it, I think Raspberry Pi is a good package as compared to the others. It has good interfacing capabilities. It can have good accelerated multimedia capabilities, which many of these devices offer.

What is the Raspberry Pi summer code contest that you have announced?

This contest is for students. I think students should be taught coding not only to get into a job but also to program their own machines. They should be given some incentives to get into programming. It is a high-frequency competition. The idea is to provide an opportunity where students are motivated to program. We want students from all parts of the world to participate in this and we are hopeful that we will see some very good apps coming out.

Can you provide the software details of Raspberry Pi?

Currently, it runs Debian Linux. Actually, it runs a version of Debian Linux called Raspbian, which is customised for the Raspberry Pi. Raspbian introduces more comprehensive support for floating-point operations. This is the result of an enormous amount of hard work by the team over the past couple of months and replaces the existing Debian squeeze image.

Small-sized computers and low-cost tablets have become a rage. What is the minimum investment required to develop a proper computing device?

It is hard to develop a good computing device for less than \$20. The processor costs around \$5. The memory costs \$4-5. The PCB and a bunch of connectors may cost around \$5. Putting them together may cost another \$5. So a computing machine cannot be made in less than \$20.

How do you see India as a market for Raspberry Pi?

India is a really important market for a device like Raspberry Pi. Indians have recently shown a lot of interest in low-cost computing devices and Raspberry Pi can be a great alternative for those who want to have a good computing device.

Do you plan to join hands with the Indian government to take the product to schools?

We have not gone ahead to discuss this so far. But the Raspberry Pi Foundation would not mind if the government in India finds our device exciting enough to give it to their students. We are open to work on such lines. ●

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